

Lean Mean Portable Machine

Agent 001 goes the extra lap in mobility

I woke up yesterday with an itch. A decidedly technology-related itch. I realised I needed something slim and trendy on my arm; something that would place me with the jet-setters, the Who's who; something that would scream my importance. In short, I needed a laptop. Of course I haven't made my thousands yet, let alone my millions, so price was a question. And with a reputation to live up to, I also wanted the best and latest hardware. So that's how began another trip to Lamington Road.

Three shops down, and not a laptop in sight; the fourth one sold branded PCs. The only guy in the shop was sitting comfortably behind a desk. Upon hearing "...laptop", he offered his assistance with a suspiciously sweet smile. He told me a Compaq with an AMD processor, 20 GB hard disk, 128 MB RAM and a CD-ROM would cost me Rs 75,000. Since I wanted a CD-Writer too, he suggested another model for Rs 1,07,000 with a combination

drive. This was another AMD, but he couldn't tell me what model it was. In fact, he didn't even have any literature, or brochures. A little more probing brought out the truth—he didn't sell anything but Compaq, and had little or no knowledge about computers.

A few hops later, I landed at a swanky-looking shop with some laptops on display. I gave the man a quick rundown of my requirements, and he immediately whipped out an IBM leaflet with two ThinkPad models—one was the 2684B2A with a Pentium 4 1.8 GHz M processor, 128 MB DDR RAM, 20 GB hard drive and a 24x CD-ROM drive. This was listed as Rs 89,500, which he offered for Rs 80,000.

There was also the 2682RA5 with a 2 GHz processor, 256 MB RAM, a 40 GB hard disk, combination drive and 32 MB of video memory. This baby would lighten my bank balance by Rs 1,09,000, and had a 3-year international warranty. This guy knew what he was talking about. He also pointed out that Firewire was missing and could be found on Sony laptops. Unfortunately, Sony has two caveats, "They don't service in India and start at Rs 1.2 lakhs." That quickly erased them from my mind, and I asked for something even cheaper than the IBMs. He offered me refurbished Compaq laptops, brought from the US. He explained that companies buy back laptops, fix them and re-sell them. He had a 500 MHz Pentium III with 64 MB RAM, a DVD ROM drive and an external floppy drive—all for Rs 42,000, but without guarantee. He offered me a 1 year comprehensive warranty (supported by him, not Compaq), for Rs 5000 extra. I was tempted, but considered the extra costs—an external CD-Writer (Rs 5,700), 64 MB RAM (Rs 1,000) and a PCMCIA Ethernet Card (Rs 1,500). Too much! I moved on.

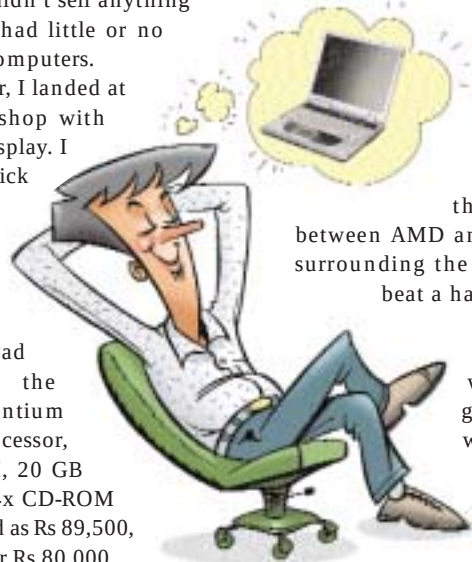
I decided to check out some PC retail outlets. The first one I visited did not have any laptops on display, but had a printed sheet listing the specifications of all the units on offer—all Compaq. The salesman recommended an AMD processor-based laptop. According to him the only difference between AMD and P4, is all the hype surrounding the P4—thanking him, I beat a hasty retreat.

The next shop had a few laptops on display which I could actually go play with, whilst I waited for a salesman.

Two of them caught my eye; one was a very stylish Toshiba Tecra with a spacious

15-inch screen. The other was an average-looking Acer, but what was so interesting about it was the fact that it ran Linux! Once a salesman was free, I asked about what was on offer. Again I got a printed sheet. A quick scan revealed that the Tecra that I loved was a whopping Rs 1,30,000 whilst the Acer 233FX was a measly Rs 55,000, but only featured a CD-ROM drive. The Tecra S1 comes with Intel Centrino technology that includes WiFi. Also packed in was a 1.4 GHz Pentium M processor and 256 MB DDR RAM.

I decided to give myself a day or two to think over it. I went home to find an advertisement for an Acer 2.4 GHz Celeron for just 49,999. Intrigued, I called the local dealer and found out that I would have to add Rs 2,000 for freight, insurance and a carry bag; an additional 4 per cent for sales tax and 5.5 per cent more for Octroi. Still a sweet deal! The only thing that disappointed me was the lack of a CD-Writer. So I decided to wait a while, let the prices fall and my bank balance rise, so I could get something that would make me smile. ■



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- A 15-inch screen looks great, but adds a lot in weight and price. Similarly a 3 GHz CPU will exhaust your battery very quickly, and won't be of any use on long trips. So choose carefully.
- If you want a CD-Writer, make sure you buy a laptop with one included—an external device takes away from the mobility of a laptop.
- Firewire, USB2, WiFi and Infra-red are important features that will connect your laptop with your existing devices. Be sure to look for them.
- Handle the device before buying it. No specification sheet or comparison table will tell you that the build quality is flimsy, or that 4 Kgs is more than your arm can take.
- Try the various pointing devices to determine which works best for you.
- Check the repair policies of the manufacturer, the warranty type and how conveniently the service centers are located.